Definiteness and Deitality in English: A Projectibility-First Account

Brett Reynolds [*]
Humber Polytechnic & University of Toronto

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Abstract

I separate the semantic category of DEFINITENESS from the structural category I call DEITALITY. Deitality is a projectible grammatical profile: its central properties include resistance as the pivot of existential *there* under neutral prosody, eligibility as the complement of partitive *of*, suitability as a host for nonrestrictive modification and identificational constructions, and a strong tendency to mark semantically definite referents. Definiteness is the semantic profile with which deitality usually aligns: identifiability, uniqueness, and anaphoric recoverability. The two profiles are strongly correlated but not identical. Their imperfect alignment explains weak definites, generic definites, narrative *this*, and cases where proper names or bare nominals are semantically definite yet morphosyntactically non-deital. The account is projectibility-first: a category is justified by the inferences it supports, not by a necessary-and-sufficient definition. Deitality earns its place because it predicts which diagnostics travel together, which pieces of the profile survive semantic mismatch, and which dimensions of the system vary across prosody, dialect, construction, and acquisition.

Keywords: definiteness; article; demonstratives; determinatives; projectibility

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1 Introduction

English grammars routinely conflate morphosyntactic form with semantic function. When it comes to definiteness, this conflation creates persistent empirical problems. Tests that target morphosyntax, like the definiteness effect in existential *there*, are treated as direct probes of uniqueness or familiarity. Meanwhile, semantic heuristics, like asking whether it makes sense to say *which one?*, are used to define grammatical categories. The result is a theoretical tangle where neither form nor meaning gets a clean characterization.

I propose a controlled decoupling. The structural category, which I call DEITALITY, is defined by a profile of distributional properties that co-occur in English determinatives and in the DP constructions they help realize. The semantic category DEFINITENESS is defined by a distinct profile of interpretive properties related to referent identifiability. Deitality is morphosyntactic but often semantically definite; definiteness is semantic but often morphosyntactically deital. The correlation is strong. The identity is absent.

This misalignment produces well-known puzzles. So-called "weak definites" like *go to the hospital* (I retain the label though the analysis here treats them as deital but indefinite) combine deital morphology with semantically indefinite reference. "Generic definites" like *The tiger is endangered* are deital but involve kind reference rather than individual-level definiteness. And proper names are semantically definite yet morphosyntactically non-deital. These are classic cases of form–function mismatch (Francis & Michaelis, 2003): the morphosyntactic and semantic categories systematically come apart.

The theoretical apparatus comes from natural-kind theory, but the payoff is linguistic. I treat deitality as a projectible grammatical profile in the tradition of homeostatic property-cluster (HPC) theory (Boyd, 1991, 1999). A projectible profile combines a contingent cluster of properties with enough order and maintenance to support inference. No single property is required, membership is graded, and boundary placement can shift over time. What makes the category coherent is that partial evidence about one part of the profile licenses expectations about the rest.

The revision from a simple HPC account matters. Not every stable profile is homeostatic in a strict sense. The later literature distinguishes stable clustering, network order, maintenance, and corrective control (Khalidi, 2013, 2018; Onishi & Serpico, 2022; Reynolds, 2026; Slater, 2015). The linguistic claim below needs stability, ordering, and enough maintenance to explain why the profile persists; it does not need to show that English deitality is a single corrective-control system.

The relevant sources and stabilizers operate at distinct timescales. Grammaticalization creates much of the profile historically when demonstratives become articles; acquisition filters it as each generation learns the system; interactive alignment, prestige selection, and iterated transmission plausibly stabilize parts of it across conversations, communities, and generations. Definiteness, by contrast, is maintained by discourse-pragmatic pressures: common ground management, bridging, and topic continuity create correlations among identifiability, uniqueness, and anaphoric tracking. The profiles overlap substantially (most deital marking appears on definite referents), and their partly distinct stabilizers let us predict where the overlap will hold and where it'll loosen.

The payoff is empirical before it's philosophical. The projectibility-first framework explains why deitality and definiteness align without being identical, why weak and generic definites exist, and why proper names pattern as they do. It also tells us what to expect once we identify a determinative, DP, or construction as more or less deital: which residues should survive semantic mismatch, which dia-

gnostics should split under manipulation, and which parts of the system should vary across prosodic, dialectal, and developmental conditions. Theoretically, it offers a principled way to embrace graded category membership: categories can have prototypical members and gradient edges while remaining real and explanatorily useful.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 introduces the projectibility-first framework and justifies its application to grammatical categories. Section 3 characterizes definiteness as a semantic profile. Section 4 develops the diagnostics for deitality as morphosyntactic tests. Section 5 identifies sources and stabilizers of the deital profile and derives empirical predictions. Section 6 applies the framework to weak and generic definites. Section 7 addresses edge cases and objections. Section 8 concludes.

2 Projectible profiles and grammatical categories

The proposal to treat deitality as a projectible grammatical profile requires justification. The framework is Boydian in motivation: it rejects necessary-and-sufficient definitions and asks what classifications let us infer. But it also incorporates a later discipline from natural-kind theory: stability, network order, maintenance, and strict homeostasis are not the same achievement.

2.1 From essence to projectibility

The motivating contrast comes from the species problem. Essentialist definitions of species sought a set of necessary and sufficient conditions for membership: morphological similarity, ability to interbreed, shared ancestry, or some other privileged property. Each candidate failed. Ring species can interbreed with adjacent populations but not with distant ones. Asexually reproducing organisms do not interbreed at all. Morphologically similar organisms can be reproductively isolated. The natural world resisted any single fixed cutoff (Mayr, 1942).

Boyd's solution was to reject essentialism. A species isn't defined by a single property or fixed list of properties. It's characterized by a cluster of properties (morphological, genetic, behavioural) that co-occur more often than chance would predict. What matters for scientific practice is projectibility: observing some parts of the profile licenses expectations about others (Boyd, 1991, 1999). The category is useful because it fits inferential practice to real causal structure, not because it mirrors an essence.

This gives three commitments that are useful for grammar. First, the category has a contingent property profile: a family of properties that statistically co-occur. Second, the profile has enough order or maintenance to keep the co-occurrence from being accidental. Third, the profile is projectible for some analytical purpose. Because these conditions are not essentialist, the resulting category can show graded membership, prototype effects, and historically mobile boundaries without collapsing into arbitrariness.

2.2 Separating stability, maintenance, and control

The word homeostatic should not do more work than the evidence warrants. In the HPC-derived debate, a profile can be stable without a known maintainer; it can be network-ordered without feedback; and it can be maintained without being a corrective-control system (Khalidi, 2013, 2018; Onishi & Serpico, 2022; Slater, 2015). A stricter diagnostic therefore asks five questions in order (Reynolds, 2026):

(i) What's the projection target?
(ii) What stable profile supports that projection?

(iii) What ordering relations explain why the projection is not accidental?
(iv) What maintains the profile across relevant timescales?
(v) Is the maintainer a corrective-control process that preserves a higher-scale relation through lower-scale variation?

This paper doesn't need the fifth step. The central linguistic claim is that deitality is a projectible grammatical profile, not that English determinatives form a homeostatic control system. Its projection targets include more than the diagnostics that first identify it. They include external and manipulable outcomes: which residues survive when semantic definiteness is relaxed, which contrasts are rescued by prosody, which frames vary across dialects, and which restrictions should be acquired earlier than others. A category is useful only if it licenses those further inferences.

2.3 Why grammatical categories need this framework

The parallel to linguistics is direct. Just as biologists sought an essence for species, linguists have sought one for definiteness. Decades of research have tried to define "definite noun phrase" by semantic essence, usually uniqueness (Hawkins, 1978; Russell, 1905) or familiarity (Christophersen, 1939; Heim, 1982). But counterexamples proliferate. Weak definites like *listen to the radio* use *the* without uniqueness (Aguilar-Guevara & Zwarts, 2010; Carlson & Sussman, 2005). Generic definites like *The lion is noble* refer to kinds, not individuals (Carlson, 1977; Krifka, 2004). Cross-linguistically, definite articles appear in contexts where their semantic contribution seems redundant or absent (Lyons, 1999).

These aren't peripheral exceptions. They're systematic patterns that suggest the category lacks a simple essence. The attempt to define a morphosyntactic object, the category of noun phrases marked with definite morphology, using purely semantic criteria has produced a category that doesn't align with the empirical facts.

The projectibility-first framework offers a way forward. We can characterize deitality and definiteness as distinct profiles and ask what each lets us infer. The strong correlation between them is real and grounded in grammar, discourse, history, and acquisition, but the profiles can come apart in systematic ways (Francis & Michaelis, 2003). The subsequent sections develop this account: §3 characterizes definiteness as the relevant semantic profile, §4 establishes deitality through convergent diagnostics, and §5 shows how deitality supports predictions across constructions, dialects, and developmental stages.

This move has precedent. Prototype theory in cognitive linguistics has long recognized that categories have graded structure (Lakoff, 1987; Rosch, 1978). But prototype theory often stops at similarity structure. Boyd's HPC framework adds a causal account of why certain properties cluster and why that clustering supports reliable inferences beyond the data that first identified it.

The framework has already been applied to linguistic phenomena. Miller (2021) argues that word-kinds like *table* and *Paris* are HPCs, defined by clusters of phonological, orthographic, and semantic properties maintained by cognitive and social mechanisms. This paper extends that style of analysis from lexical ontology to grammatical categories, but with a stricter vocabulary. Where Miller asks what makes tokens instances of the same word-kind, I ask what distinguishes deital from non-deital determinatives: why *the*, *this*, and genitives pattern together distributionally while *a*, *some*, and *many* form a contrasting profile.

3 Definiteness as a semantic profile

Before characterizing deitality, I need to clarify what definiteness is, semantically and pragmatically, so the contrast with deitality is clear. The literature presents two major traditions: uniqueness theories and familiarity theories. Rather than adjudicating between them, I argue that both capture important properties in the definiteness profile.

Uniqueness theories originate with Russell (Russell, 1905). A definite description *the F* presupposes that exactly one entity satisfies *F* in the contextually relevant domain. Later work refined this to allow pragmatic restriction: uniqueness holds relative to a "P-set" or shared frame of reference (Hawkins, 1978). This approach handles "larger situation" uses like *the sun* and anaphoric uses where prior discourse has narrowed the context to a single salient entity.

Familiarity theories stem from Christophersen and were formalized by Heim (Christophersen, 1939; Heim, 1982). Definite noun phrases are subject to a familiarity condition: they have to refer to an entity already established in the discourse model. Indefinites, by contrast, introduce new referents. This framework excels at explaining discourse anaphora, where a definite's felicity depends directly on having a linguistic antecedent.

Both theories have problems. Familiarity isn't necessary: *the first person on Mars* can be used felicitously even when the referent is discourse-new. Uniqueness isn't sufficient: in contexts with two familiar but non-unique entities, neither *the N* works smoothly. And weak definites challenge both: *go to the hospital* uses *the* when the hospital is neither uniquely specified nor discourse-familiar (Abbott, 2004; Birner, 2013).

I propose that uniqueness and familiarity are both properties in the definiteness profile, along with anaphoric recoverability and, more broadly, identifiability. These properties co-tend because of discourse-pragmatic pressures: common ground management makes unique entities easier to track; anaphoric devices rely on familiarity; topics bias toward identifiable referents. But the co-occurrence is statistical, not absolute.

This explains the theoretical debate. Uniqueness and familiarity theorists aren't discovering competing essences. They're mapping different regions of the same semantic profile. The properties overlap heavily (a discourse-old, unique referent satisfies both), but they dissociate in predictable ways. Weak definites have identifiability without token-level uniqueness. Cataphoric definites have uniqueness without prior familiarity. The semantic notion of definiteness is therefore profile-like rather than essence-like.

Definiteness is a profile centred on interpretation: how referents are mentally represented and tracked in discourse. The core properties are identifiability, uniqueness, and anaphoric recoverability. The profile also includes a morphological tendency: definite referents are strongly associated with deital marking. This association is maintained by discourse efficiency and grammaticalization history, creating substantial overlap with deitality. The next sections establish the deital profile through convergent diagnostics (§4) and identify the distinct processes maintaining it (§5). The imperfect alignment between profiles, cases where definiteness and deitality dissociate, is the focus of §6.

4 Diagnostics for deitality

I characterize deitality as a structural profile whose core comprises distributional restrictions but also includes a strong tendency to mark semantically definite referents. The profile is level-sensitive. Sometimes the relevant object is a determinative lexeme (*the*, *this*, genitive *'s*); sometimes it's a DP

in a particular construction; sometimes it's a diachronic lineage whose forms preserve inherited distributional residue. Deitality is therefore not a single feature borne by one grammatical object in all contexts. It's the category that answers a syntactician's question: which forms and constructions support the same projectible distributional inferences?

This section develops four diagnostics of unequal strength: existential *there*, partitive *of*, identificational hosting, and *one*-substitution. Partitive *Y*-licensing is the strongest syntactic diagnostic. Existential *there* is constructional and information-structurally sensitive. Identificational hosting is mixed: it reflects morphosyntax, specificity, and discourse anchoring. *One*-substitution is a fragile corroborating cue. The tests are useful precisely because they do not reduce to one another.

4.1 Existential ⟨there⟩

The definiteness effect in existential *there* constructions is well documented (McNally, 2011; Milsark, 1977). Under neutral prosody, deital determinatives resist the pivot position:

(1) a. **There is the key on the table.*
b. **There are those books I mentioned.*
c. *There is a key on the table.* (non-deital, acceptable)

The effect is sensitive to prosody: list/presentational intonation can license otherwise dispreferred pivots (Birner & Ward, 1998):

(2) a. *There's THAT book again.*
b. *Well, there's the KEYS, the wallet...*

Cris Chatterjee noted that the initial *there* in such cases can be heard as locative rather than expletive, which makes the intended presentational reading harder to obtain.

I treat this as a controllable neutralization: under neutral prosody, deital determinatives resist the pivot position; marked prosody can ameliorate the effect. The diagnostic is therefore calibrated to neutral prosody.

This calibration matters. Existential *there* has semantic and information-structure inputs, so list readings, recurrence readings, locative/expletive ambiguity, and narrative frames can affect judgments. I use it as a ranked cue under neutral prosody and non-narrative frames, not as sufficient evidence for deitality.

McNally (2011) is especially important because the definiteness restriction is not treated there as a simple surface-form ban. McNally reviews semantic accounts on which the pivot has to be property-like and pragmatic accounts on which the pivot is constrained by discourse status or information structure; her own earlier analysis is explicitly mixed. I accept that lesson. The *there* diagnostic does not by itself show a morphosyntactic category distinct from definiteness. Its value here is comparative: it patterns with the profile under neutral conditions, but it dissociates from the harder partitive diagnostic under prosodic manipulation. The contrast between prosodically defeasible *there* effects and prosodically rigid partitive *Y*-licensing is what makes the cue useful for deitality.

4.2 Partitive ⟨of⟩

In true partitive constructions (*X of Y* with subset semantics), the relevant diagnostic is not article-marked definiteness as such but the availability of a delimited domain. I state the diagnostic this

way: the *Y* complement has to be definite-like or independently domain-establishing (Barker, 1998; Hoeksema, 1996):

(3) a. *Two / several / many of the students left.*
b. *Two / several / many of these / my students left.*

(4) **Two / several / many of some students left.*

This selectional restriction is stable and not ameliorated by prosody. The partitive literature contains complications, including examples such as *one of several options*, *one of many problems*, and *two of a number of applicants*. Those cases show that the domain-establishing condition can be satisfied without the article *the*. They do not erase the diagnostic contrast at issue here: ordinary weak indefinites like *some students* do not behave like *the students*, *these students*, or genitive DPs as partitive complements. Attempts to use weak *Y* are either rejected outright, receive a specialized set-denoting interpretation, or are reanalyzed as measure/fraction constructions (*half of a cake*), which have different semantics.

The *Y* slot is what matters. Elements in *X*, including quantifiers like *all* or *both* when they appear as modifiers, are irrelevant to this diagnostic.

4.3 Identificational hosting

Deital determinatives are preferred hosts for nonrestrictive modification, topics, and specificational subjects. Weak determinatives are degraded unless coerced to specific readings (Lambrecht, 1994):

(5) a. *The / this / John's book, which I bought yesterday, is excellent.*
b. *As for the / this / John's report, I filed it.*
c. *The culprit is John.*

(6) a. ??*A book, which I bought yesterday, is excellent.*
b. ??*As for a report, I filed it.*
c. ??*A culprit is John.*

The degradation correlates with information structure. Identificational constructions presuppose that the referent is already salient or identifiable to the hearer. Weak indefinites introduce new referents and clash with this presupposition. This diagnostic is therefore mixed rather than purely structural: examples such as *A colleague of mine, who you may remember from York, emailed me* improve because specificity and discourse anchoring supply part of what the construction requires. The prediction is graded, not categorical.

4.4 ⟨One⟩-substitution

Non-deital determinatives freely allow bare anaphoric *one* across clauses:

(7) *I bought a red pen and you bought one too.*

Deital packages resist bare *one* in the same configuration:

(8) **I bought the / this / my red pen and you bought one too.*

Determiner function + *one* (*this one*, *the one*) is grammatical but represents a different construction: *one* is a noun with its own determiner, not a determinative phrase in fused-determiner–head function (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 332–333). I exclude this construction from the diagnostic.

This test is narrower than the others, more subject to dialectal variation, and sensitive to what the antecedent of *one* is taken to be. Many speakers accept examples like *I found the perfect apartment and she found one too*, where *one* recovers the nominal property rather than the whole DP. I therefore treat the test as a corroborating cue rather than a primary diagnostic.

4.5 Summary: Converging evidence for a grammatical profile

These four diagnostics converge on a morphosyntactic profile, but they aren't equally stable. Prototypical deital determinatives resist existential pivots, satisfy the domain-establishing *Y* condition in partitives, host identificational constructions naturally, and disprefer bare *one*-substitution. Prototypical non-deital determinatives show the opposite pattern. No single diagnostic defines the profile. Partitive *Y*-licensing has the greatest syntactic weight; existential *there* and hosting show how the profile interacts with information structure; *one*-substitution is a narrow residue. What matters is ranked convergence across tests, a profile that essentialist accounts cannot capture.

In applying the tests (see Appendix A), many determinatives show partial membership. Items like *each*, *every*, *all*, and *both* resist existential pivots (patterning deitally) but fail other diagnostics (patterning non-deitally). A projectible-profile account predicts this graded membership: different degrees of property convergence. The diagnostic convergence defines a space where *the* and demonstratives occupy the prototypical centre while other items show gradient participation.

This property pluralism is central to the framework: just as biological species are characterized by multiple co-tending traits (morphology, genetics, behaviour) with none metaphysically prior, deitality is characterized by multiple co-tending distributional properties with none foundational. The diagnostics are not interchangeable, but their dissociations are informative rather than embarrassing.

Some diagnostics are more reliable in practice. Some show more cross-linguistic stability; some resist dialectal variation better; some apply more broadly. The *one*-substitution test, for instance, is more subject to dialectal variation than partitive *Y*-licensing, making it a less stable probe in fieldwork. These are empirical differences in diagnostic utility and in the grammatical levels being tested, not grounds for reducing the profile to one semantic feature.

These diagnostics target distributional behaviour rather than semantic contribution. This does not mean the deital profile lacks semantic tendencies: it correlates strongly with identifiability, wide scope, and anaphoric tracking. But these tendencies are part of the profile, not necessary conditions for membership. A determinative can be deital while contributing non-prototypical semantics: weak definites lack token-level uniqueness; generic definites refer to kinds. The morphosyntactic profile is what remains stable across this semantic variation.

The term DEITALITY is therefore not a synonym for older labels such as STRONG, SPECIFIC, PRESUPPOSITIONAL, D-LINKED, FAMILIAR, or UNIQUE. Those labels name semantic, discourse, or construction-specific properties. A Milsark-style strong/weak contrast captures part of the existential pattern but does not predict the same behaviour in partitive *Y*-licensing or narrative *this*. Specificity and D-linking improve hosting but do not by themselves supply domain-establishing *Y* complements. Familiarity and uniqueness describe the semantic centre of definiteness but overpredict alignment in weak definites and names. Deitality names the projectible distributional profile whose

prototype comes from demonstrative-derived determinatives and whose residues persist when those semantic properties come apart.

Section 5 identifies the processes that source and stabilize this diagnostic profile.

5 Sources and stabilizers of the deital profile

The central claim of a projectible-profile account is that property convergence is not accidental. For deitality, the evidence is strongest for a diachronic source and a learning filter: grammaticalization creates much of the profile, and acquisition plausibly helps reproduce it in each generation. Other processes (interactive alignment, prestige selection, and iterated transmission) are plausible stabilizers of particular parts of the profile, especially at gradient margins. I therefore treat them as ranked contributors rather than as proof of a single rich homeostatic mechanism. For definiteness, the relevant pressures are discourse-pragmatic: information structure and common ground management create correlations among identifiability, uniqueness, and anaphoric recoverability, while also reinforcing the tendency for definite referents to be marked deitally.

The previous section established diagnostic properties that converge to define the deital profile. This section identifies sources and stabilizers operating at distinct timescales and derives falsifiable predictions about synchronic grammar.

5.1 Sources and stabilizers across timescales

Grammaticalization creates much of the profile over phylogenetic time. Cross-linguistically, definite articles arise primarily from demonstratives (Diessel, 1999; Greenberg, 1978). As a demonstrative grammaticalizes (weakening phonologically and broadening functionally), it does not shed its distributional properties. It drags them along.

Demonstratives inherently show many properties of the deital profile. They're deictic, which makes them poor candidates for introducing discourse-new referents (hence resistance to existential *there*). They're referential and often presuppositional, which makes them natural hosts for identificational constructions. They pattern with definites in partitive constructions cross-linguistically.

When a demonstrative becomes an article, these distributional tendencies persist. The resulting article inherits the morphosyntactic frame even as its semantic function generalizes from pure deixis to broader identifiability marking. I call this property dragging: grammaticalization preserves formal behaviour while semantic function shifts.

English *the* shows this pattern. Historically derived from a demonstrative, it resists existential pivots, appears as a domain-establishing *Y* in partitives, and hosts identificational constructions, all properties traceable to its deictic source. Weak definites, where *the* appears without uniqueness, represent cases where the morphosyntactic frame has outlived the original semantic restriction.

The grammaticalization account predicts that items sharing a deictic source should share distributional properties. English offers a modest lineage residue of this kind. The /ð/-initial determinatives (*the*, *this*, *that*, *these*, *those*) are all deital and all belong to the inherited Germanic demonstrative family. The pattern is not a diagnostic: other function words like *then*, *than*, and *though* begin with /ð/ without being determinatives, and many deital items like genitives lack /ð/ entirely. But within determinatives, the phonological clustering usefully reminds us that the distributional profile is historically carried by forms. Property dragging operates on bundles: when demonstratives grammaticalize, they can carry along both distributional behaviour and phonological shape.

First language acquisition filters the hypothesis space in childhood. Each new generation has to acquire the grammatical system. The acquisition process acts as a filter: only stable, learnable patterns survive transmission.

Children acquire deital determinatives early, often overgeneralizing *the* to contexts where adults use *a* (Maratsos, 1976; Rozendaal & Baker, 2008). This need not be pure semantic confusion. It's compatible with a structural-learning story: children identify a high-frequency form (*the*) plus parts of its distributional frame and apply it broadly before refining the semantic conditions.

The stronger developmental claim remains conditional. Children may master some positions for *the* before the full pragmatic conditions on adult use. The overgeneralization asymmetry is still positive evidence for a structural-learning story: children seem to latch onto *the* and parts of its frame before the adult semantic conditions are fully in place. But the relative timing of specific restrictions, including partitive *Y*-licensing, still needs direct evidence. If borne out, this would create a bootstrapping path: the distributional frame helps learners infer semantic function, and vice versa.

On this view, acquisitional filtering helps maintain the profile's stability. Each generation recreates the deitality category from distributional and interpretive evidence. The stronger prediction is that children should not learn pivot resistance, partitive *Y*-licensing, and identificational hosting as wholly unrelated facts. They should show patterned asymmetries as they refine semantic conditions while preserving parts of the morphosyntactic frame.

Interactive alignment and repair stabilize local patterns over seconds and minutes. In conversation, speakers converge on syntactic frames and repair misalignments (Pickering & Garrod, 2004). When a speaker produces a deital determinative in a dispreferred context, say *There's the problem* under neutral prosody, hearers may flag the anomaly through correction, hesitation, or clarification requests. This feedback stabilizes local distributional patterns, but it does not by itself show a single control system maintaining deitality as a whole.

The stabilizer operates largely below conscious awareness. Speakers do not explicitly reason about partitive *Y*-licensing restrictions; they simply experience discomfort when hearing **two of some students* and either repair the utterance or signal non-comprehension. Over thousands of conversational exchanges, this microgenetic pruning reinforces the profile by penalizing violations and rewarding canonical patterns.

Prestige-weighted selection shapes social stratification over decades. High-status variants spread faster through communities (Eckert, 2000; Labov, 2001), pushing some constructions toward categorical bans while allowing sociolinguistic stratification at gradient margins.

For deitality, this stabilizer may help explain why some weak definite frames (British *in hospital*) become dialectally entrenched while others never stabilize. Prestige effects can override frequency: highly frequent non-standard patterns (*them books* in some dialects) remain marked because standard *those books* carries social prestige. Conversely, low-frequency prestige forms can resist elimination.

This process does not create the deital profile (grammaticalization and acquisition supply the main explanation), but it can shape which variants survive community transmission and which get filtered out. This explains why structural bans often correlate with social evaluation even when the underlying constraint is cognitive or morphosyntactic.

Iterated cultural transmission filters the system across generations. The transmission bottleneck amplifies learnability biases and filters out mappings that exceed processing or memory constraints (Kirby et al., 2014). Each generation learns the language from finite input, necessarily discarding

patterns that are too complex, too rare, or too inconsistent to acquire reliably.

This multi-generational ratchet explains why structural bans converge across dialects even as surface patterns diverge. Determinative extraction (**Which did you buy car?*) is categorically rejected in all English dialects because the underlying constraint, no stranding of determinatives, is simple, learnable, and stable under transmission. Weak definite frames, by contrast, show dialectal variation because they're conventionalized idioms: learnable but not structurally forced.

Iterated transmission can also preserve the phonological residue noted in the grammaticalization discussion above. The /ð/-initial family need not have any functional advantage; it persists because the forms themselves are stable under transmission.

5.2 Causal architecture: How the sources and stabilizers interact

Figure 1 schematizes how these processes can stabilize the deital profile. Grammaticalization creates much of the initial bundle; the other processes reproduce, filter, or reshape it at different timescales.

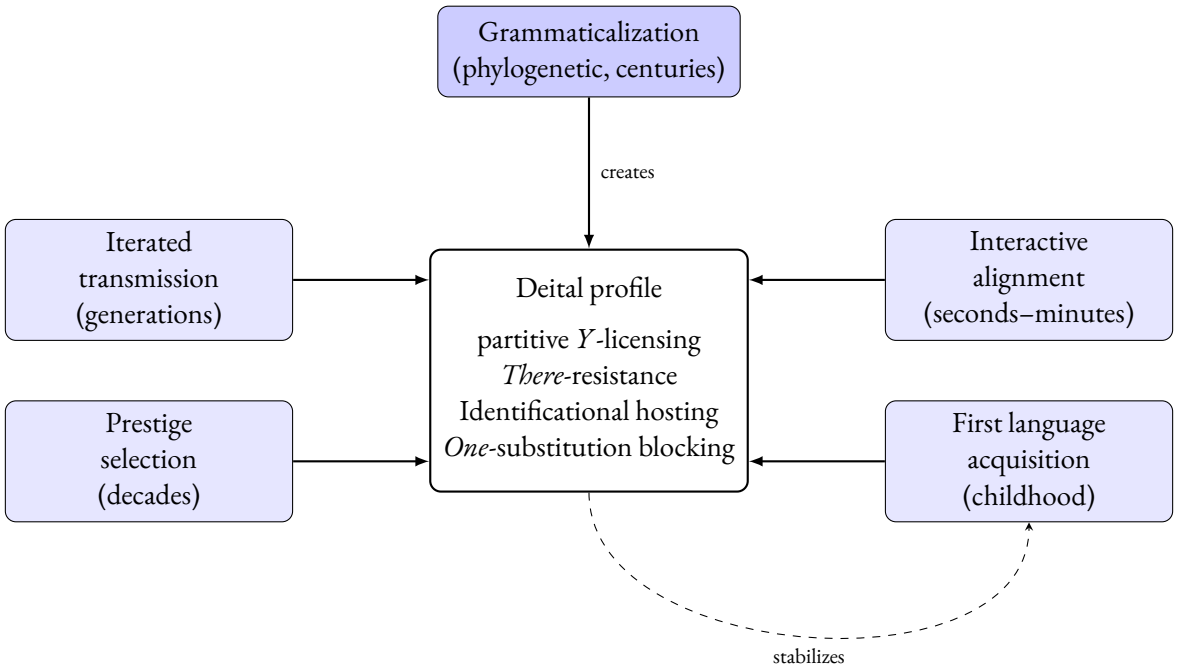


Figure 1: Processes stabilizing the deital profile. Grammaticalization (top) created much of the initial property bundle through demonstrative-to-article pathways. The other processes reproduce, filter, or reshape the profile at different timescales: iterated transmission filters for learnability across generations; prestige-weighted selection shapes social distribution over decades; interactive alignment maintains patterns in real-time conversation; first language acquisition helps reproduce the profile in each generation. The profile's stability feeds back to enable successful acquisition (bottom), creating a self-reinforcing cycle. Solid arrows show primary causation; dashed arrow shows feedback.

The architecture reveals why deitality is stable yet variable. Grammaticalization creates much of the initial property bundle through demonstrative-to-article pathways. Acquisition filters this input, preserving learnable patterns. Interactive alignment may stabilize the profile in real-time conversa-

tional practice. Prestige selection shapes which variants survive socially. Iterated transmission filters patterns that cannot survive the multi-generational bottleneck.

The feedback loop at the bottom of Figure 1 is critical. Once the profile stabilizes, it becomes the target of acquisition: children learn the stable pattern, which reinforces its stability in the next generation. This positive feedback explains why the deital profile persists despite constant pressure from analogy, frequency effects, and contact-induced change.

5.3 Why deitality and definiteness correlate imperfectly

Grammaticalization and acquisition explain why deitality exists as a stable morphosyntactic profile. But why does it correlate with definiteness? And why is the correlation not perfect?

The correlation arises because the deictic sources of articles were themselves sensitive to information structure. Demonstratives mark salient, often identifiable referents. As they grammaticalize, this functional tendency becomes conventionalized. Speakers and hearers coordinate on using the article for identifiable referents because that's what the form conventionally signals.

This coordination is maintained by communicative efficiency. Speakers remember frequent pairings, *the* plus unique/familiar referents, and hearers expect them. When speakers violate expectations, hearers accommodate by adjusting their domain of evaluation, coercing to specific readings, or reanalyzing the structure. This creates a stable equilibrium where form and function align statistically.

But the correlation is not perfect because grammaticalization preserves formal residue. Weak definites like *take the bus* reflect conventionalized frames where *the* appeared because of institutional or habitual association, and that morphosyntactic pattern persisted even as the semantic contribution remained indefinite. The distributional residue (appears with *the*, resists modification, allows only certain verb–noun pairs) is the grammaticalized fossil of a construction, not of a semantic feature.

The mismatch also reflects constructional autonomy. Once a morphosyntactic pattern is established, it can be recruited for new functions. *The poor* and *the unknown* as fused modifier–head NPs use *the* to signal definiteness at the constructional level, not the lexical level. The frame itself becomes meaningful, semi-independent of the article's core function.

5.4 Projectibility tests: Evidence that deitality is a useful category

A category earns its place by supporting inductive and explanatory practice. Deitality earns that place when partial evidence about its profile lets us predict untested behaviour. Recognizing a deital profile should tell us something new about constructions, dialects, and learning paths.

The first test concerns residual behaviour under semantic mismatch. Constructional mismatches provide the sharpest test. Once a construction recruits deital morphology while relaxing canonical definiteness, the projectibility-first account predicts selective residue rather than global weakening. Narrative *this* is the clearest case. If *There was this guy at the door* reflects constructional recruitment of deital form, we should expect the construction to license narrative presentation while preserving other deital restrictions:

- *There was this guy at the door...* remains acceptable because the construction packages narrative presentation with deital morphology.
- A singular narrative *this guy* cannot supply the plural domain required by *two of*; plural *these guys* can do so only by establishing a referential group.
- **I met this guy and you met one too* remains bad on the narrow reading where bare *one* has to recover the DP package rather than merely the nominal property.

That inference is projectibility. A semantics-first analysis identifies discourse-new reference. The deitality analysis goes further and predicts which parts of the morphosyntactic profile should survive that semantic mismatch.

The same logic applies to weak definites and generic definites. Once they're identified as semantically unusual but morphosyntactically deital, we should expect residual deital behaviour in diagnostics tied to constructional or selectional structure, not a free-for-all of indefinite behaviour. The category is useful because it supports those selective expectations.

The second test is pathway-conditioned distribution. If deitality is sourced and stabilized by the processes in §5.1, then grammaticalization pathway and transmission regime should shape where the profile holds together and where it loosens. The prediction is conditional.

The convergence prediction is that acquisition and iterated transmission should make properties travel together more reliably than idiomatic frames tied to prestige or local convention.

The divergence prediction is that institutional frames, register-sensitive uses, and socially marked constructions should vary more than core selectional restrictions.

English already points in this direction. Dialects differ over weak definite frames such as *in hospital* versus *in the hospital*. But they do not vary freely over core determinative syntax. The projectibility-first account predicts that shape of variation because socially maintained frames are looser than selectional constraints reproduced in acquisition.

Cross-linguistically, the stronger claim is also conditional: when article systems arise from demonstratives, they should be better candidates for deital-style clustering than systems with a different diachronic source or no article system at all. It predicts family resemblances in which some properties co-travel and others separate under pressure.

The third test is the acquisitional trajectory. If the sources and stabilizers in §5.1 are correctly identified, child language acquisition should show specific developmental asymmetries. The category should let us infer a learning path from the internal organization of the profile.

First, children should master some distributional restrictions on *the* before the full pragmatic conditions on adult use.

Second, children should overgeneralize *the* to semantically inappropriate contexts while still respecting the clearest morphosyntactic constraints.

Third, children should master syntactic constraints earlier than discourse-pragmatic ones. Partitive *Y*-licensing should precede existential pivot resistance under neutral prosody.

Existing acquisition data is compatible with the first two predictions (Maratsos, 1976; Rozendaal & Baker, 2008). The third remains to be tested systematically and should be read as a forecast rather than an established result. The logic is straightforward: syntactic selectional restrictions do not yield to prosodic manipulation (see §5.5), so children cannot use prosody as a repair strategy. Discourse-pragmatic constraints do yield to prosody, giving children a fallback. The predicted asymmetry follows from the different causal bases of the constraints.

The source-and-stabilizer account also generates specific predictions about how the synchronic grammar behaves under manipulation. These predictions are the analytical payoff of the category. They distinguish this account from alternatives by targeting the interaction between morphosyntax, prosody, semantics, and development. Each prediction is falsifiable and testable.

5.5 Prosodic manipulation dissociation

Prosody should selectively rescue existential pivots but not partitive *Y* complements.

Prosody can rescue what discourse creates; prosody cannot rescue what syntax demands. Existential pivots yield to marked intonation because the construction is grammatical but mediated by information structure. Neutral prosody enforces presentational requirements; contrastive or list prosody can alter them. Partitive *Y* complements resist all prosodic manipulation because their constraint is selectional: the construction requires an appropriate *Y* domain, and prosody does not alter that relation.

The relevant test cases are:

(9) a. **There is the key on the table.* (neutral prosody: unacceptable)
b. *Well, there's THE KEY, the wallet...* (list prosody: acceptable)
c. **Two of some students passed.* (neutral prosody: unacceptable)
d. **TWO of SOME students passed.* (contrastive prosody: still unacceptable)

If contrastive prosody rescues partitive *Y* complements to the same degree it rescues existential pivots, the source-and-stabilizer explanation fails. The dissociation is predicted by the different causal bases (discourse-pragmatic vs. syntactic) of the two constraints.

5.6 Specificity forcing partial amelioration

Forcing specificity should improve indefinites in identificational environments without fully licensing them.

Making an indefinite semantically specific does not change its non-deital morphosyntactic profile. The improvement should be measurable but fall short of canonical deital hosts because the morphosyntactic mismatch persists.

The relevant test cases are:

(10) a. *??A book, which I bought yesterday, is excellent.*
b. *?A certain book, which I bought yesterday, is excellent.* (improved but still marked)
c. *The / this book, which I bought yesterday, is excellent.* (fully acceptable baseline)

Acceptability ratings should show this ordering: baseline indefinite < specific indefinite < deital baseline. If specific indefinites reach deital baseline acceptability, the morphosyntactic/semantic distinction collapses. If they show no improvement, semantic contribution is irrelevant to hosting. Partial improvement confirms that both morphosyntactic form and semantic contribution matter.

5.7 Dialectal frame interpretation

Dialectal variation in institutional frames should preserve the institutional/activity reading in the licensed frame, while demonstratives and genitives should tend to force ordinary referential readings.

The relevant test is not whether demonstratives are accepted. Demonstratives are accepted: *this hospital* and *that hospital* are ordinary referential DPs. The question is whether the weak-definite or institutional reading survives. If dialectal variation is tied to conventionalized frames rather than free alternation in determinative syntax, replacing the frame's licensed form with a demonstrative should usually shift the interpretation from 'receiving institutional care' to 'located in a particular hospital'.

The relevant test cases are:

(11) a. British English: *She is in hospital.* (institutional/activity reading)
b. American English: *She is in the hospital.* (institutional/activity reading available)

c. Both dialects: *She is in this hospital.* (acceptable, but preferentially ordinary locative/referential)

If demonstratives preserve the institutional/activity reading just as well as the dialectally licensed weak-definite frame, then the account has overstated the special status of the frame. If they instead force a referential-location reading while the licensed frame preserves the institutional reading, the profile supports the intended inference: dialects vary over frames, not freely over deital syntax.

5.8 Acquisitional asymmetries

Children should show developmental asymmetries reflecting the sources and stabilizers at work.

If the profile is maintained by acquisition, its internal structure should be visible in the learning path. Children should master hard syntactic constraints early because these lack prosodic repair paths. Softer discourse-pragmatic constraints should be mastered later.

The relevant test cases are:

(12) a. Children should correctly reject ungrammatical partitives like **two of some students* early (a hard syntactic rule).

b. Children may over-accept deitals in existential *there* contexts, especially with list or recurrence intonation, before mastering the adult-like neutral-prosody constraint (a softer, discourse-pragmatic rule).

Longitudinal acquisition studies should show partitive *Y* violations rejected earlier (by age X) than existential violations under neutral prosody (by age Y > X). The gap reflects the availability of prosodic rescue for existentials but not partitives.

5.9 Distinguishing the projectibility-first account from alternatives

These four predictions also separate the projectibility-first account from nearby alternatives.

A Milsark-style strong/weak account captures much of the existential contrast, but by itself does not predict why partitive *Y*-licensing, hosting, and narrative *this* split in the particular ways described above.

A uniqueness/familiarity account expects prosodic rescue to track referent identifiability more evenly across constructions. It therefore has trouble explaining why list prosody improves *there* pivots but not non-domain-establishing partitive *Y* complements.

A specificity or D-linking account predicts improvement under specificity forcing, but not the persistent gap between specific indefinites and deital baselines in identificational hosting.

A frame-by-frame account can describe each local frame. It does not by itself predict projection across diagnostics: knowing that an item is deital should support expectations about partitives, hosting, prosody, and mismatch residue.

A purely diachronic account explains why the family exists historically, but not why the diagnostics are synchronically ranked or why partitive *Y*-licensing resists prosodic rescue more strongly than existential pivots.

A simple feature account predicts all-or-nothing specificity effects rather than partial amelioration.

An arbitrary dialect account predicts local frame differences without systematic preservation or loss of institutional readings.

The predictions target the interaction between morphosyntax, prosody, semantics, and development, exactly what the source-and-stabilizer account predicts. They're testable through experimental work (acceptability ratings, prosodic manipulation), corpus studies (dialectal patterns), and acquisition research (developmental timelines). The projectibility-first account does more than accommodate existing data; it generates novel empirical commitments.

6 Case studies: Weak and generic definites

The explanatory power of the account is best demonstrated by long-standing puzzles. This section uses weak definites, generic definites, and narrative *this* as stress tests for projectibility. Once a construction is identified as deital, the analysis should let us predict which morphosyntactic residue survives when canonical definiteness drops out (Francis & Michaelis, 2003). These constructions do not show a perfectly clean syntax/semantics split. They show something more useful: the structural and semantic profiles are statistically coupled, partly independent, and leaky in predictable places.

6.1 Weak definites

So-called weak definite constructions like *take the bus*, *listen to the radio*, and *go to the hospital* have troubled semantic theories for decades (Aguilar-Guevara & Zwarts, 2010; Carlson & Sussman, 2005). The puzzle is how *the* appears without unique or familiar referents. Some semantic analyses invoke incorporation, kind reference, or minimal situations to preserve or refine a uniqueness-based account. Those mechanisms are important, but on their own they do not explain the full pattern: extreme sensitivity to modification, strict lexical restrictions, and enriched meanings (*go to the hospital* = 'seek medical treatment').

The projectibility-first account reframes the puzzle. Weak definites use deital morphology and inherit some distributional residue from ordinary *the*-DPs, but they do not uniformly satisfy every diagnostic. That mixed behaviour is central. They lack the definiteness-marking function that typically accompanies *the*; at the same time, they're not ordinary indefinites. They're pragmatically conventionalized frames in which deital form and token-level definiteness semantics have partly separated.

They do not contribute token-level uniqueness or familiarity. *Take the bus* does not presuppose a unique, identifiable bus; it calls up a conventional activity type. The morphosyntactic frame (verb + *the* + noun in this construction) is stable and deital in form, but the semantic contribution is non-unique reference. This form–meaning split has a permeable boundary between grammar and interpretation.

The frame does encode stereotypicality and conventionalization, which creates a weak form of identifiability: hearers recognize the activity type even when the token referent is unspecified. But this falls short of the definiteness profile's core properties (token uniqueness and anaphoric recoverability). Weak definites occupy the gap: morphosyntactically deital, semantically indefinite, pragmatically conventional.

The pattern follows from grammaticalization and constructional entrenchment. Grammaticalization preserves morphosyntactic frames while semantic function shifts. Weak definites can be analysed as entrenched constructional frames in which *the* persists because of institutional or habitual association while token-level definiteness is weakened or absent. The distributional residue (appears with *the*, resists modification, allows only certain verb–noun pairs) is the grammaticalized fossil of a construction, not of a semantic feature.

Weak definites do not pattern uniformly across all diagnostics. In partitive constructions, *two of the buses* is available only on an ordinary referential reading; *two of the bus* is odd on the weak institutional reading. This follows from the diagnostic ranking: partitive *Y*-licensing is the hardest syntactic test and does not simply yield to constructional pressure. The weak reading is available only when the frame itself licenses it. Partitives require a referentially established domain; weak definites provide institutional or activity-type identifiability. The mismatch blocks the weak reading.

6.2 Generic definites

So-called generic definites like *The lion is noble* or *The computer changed the world* pose a similar challenge. The definite singular is used for kind reference, not individual reference (Carlson, 1977; Krifka, 2004). Uniqueness holds at the kind level, but the standard application of definiteness theory targets individuals.

Again, the projectibility-first account provides clarity, though generic definites are a compatibility case rather than the strongest independent argument. A semantic account can treat *the lion* as unique or maximal at the kind level. The deitality claim is different: whatever the correct kind semantics, the DP still uses the deital morphosyntactic profile. Its behaviour therefore belongs with the residue question: which distributional properties remain when individual-level definiteness is not at issue?

English allows multiple strategies for genericity: bare plurals (*Lions are noble*), indefinite singulars (*A lion is noble*), and definite singulars (*The lion is noble*). The choice between them is conditioned by subtle semantic and pragmatic factors. Definite singulars are preferred for well-established kinds, particularly species or inventions conceived as singular abstract individuals.

What the definite singular provides is the morphosyntactic profile of deitality. The semantics is kind reference, which operates at a different level from individual reference. Individual-level uniqueness and identifiability do not apply in the usual way; kind-level properties do. The syntax generates a deital phrase; semantics assigns it a generic interpretation. This supports the distinction, but it does not by itself force the distinction against every kind-based semantic account.

This point should not be treated as independent deital residue. Generic definites resist existential *there* because the construction is geared to episodic, stage-level predication, and kind-level subjects are semantically incompatible. Bare-plural generics show the same pressure. The deitality claim is narrower: a definite singular generic retains deital morphosyntax while its semantic interpretation operates at the kind level.

6.3 Indefinite ⟨this⟩ as constructional recruitment

Colloquial English productively uses *this* with discourse-new referents in presentational and narrative contexts (Gernsbacher & Shroyer, 1989; Prince, 1981):

(13) a. *There was this guy at the door...*
b. *So I'm walking home when this dog starts following me...*

This pattern is frequent in speech and systematic across speakers, so it's not performance error or dialectal idiosyncrasy. But it strains the alignment between deitality and definiteness: demonstrative morphology appears without discourse-old or unique referents.

The account explains this as constructional recruitment. Certain narrative-presentation constructions recruit deital morphology not for ordinary definiteness but for specificity, subjective immediacy, and cataphoric accessibility. The construction selects a demonstrative-derived form while

introducing a discourse-new referent, exactly the kind of form–meaning mismatch the framework predicts when morphosyntactic frames achieve constructional autonomy (§5.3).

If narrative *this* reflects constructional recruitment rather than a separate lexical item, we predict asymmetric diagnostic behaviour:

- Existential *there*. The narrative construction licenses the combination directly. *There was this guy* is acceptable because the construction packages discourse-new reference with narrative prosody and cataphoric accessibility. The contrast with *There was a guy at the door* is not basic grammaticality; the latter is an ordinary narrative opening. The predicted contrast is discourse effect: *this* should make the referent more vivid, noteworthy, and likely to be continued.
- Partitive *Y*. The construction does not alter partitive *Y*-licensing. A singular narrative *this guy* cannot supply a plural domain for *two of*; plural demonstrative forms such as *these guys* can serve as partitive complements only when they establish a referential group. Narrative framing does not by itself create that domain.
- Identificational hosting. Narrative *this* should show intermediate acceptability, better than bare *a* (because demonstrative morphology provides the salience hosting requires) but worse than canonical deital uses (because the referent lacks discourse history). This matches the specificity-forcing prediction in §5.6.

Constructional autonomy (§5.3) explains how morphosyntactic frames, once established, can be recruited for new functions. The narrative-presentational construction in English recruits demonstrative morphology for marking specificity, immediacy, and expected continuation while introducing a discourse-new referent. It's a construction that uses deital form while relaxing ordinary definiteness semantics.

The diagnostics need not move together. The construction licenses the *there* + demonstrative combination and improves discourse accessibility, but it does not automatically alter partitive domain requirements or the narrow *one*-substitution residue. This selective pattern confirms that deitality is a profile of partly independent distributional requirements, not a unitary feature that flips wholesale.

This stability likely arises from three stabilizers:

- Acquisition packages the narrative frame with demonstrative morphology. Children do not have to decompose it into "indefinite this."
- Register and genre conventionalize the pattern in oral narrative, maintaining it across generations despite prescriptive pressure.
- Processing supports the construction because its prosodic packaging (narrative contour) signals the non-canonical semantics, preventing garden-pathing.

The constructional account makes testable predictions that distinguish it from a polysemy analysis:

First, remove the narrative frame, and the discourse effect weakens. *This guy walked in* can be acceptable as a colloquial specific indefinite, but it should be less strongly cataphoric than *There was this guy who walked in* in a story-opening frame.

Second, the construction should differentiate determinatives by discourse effect rather than by simple grammaticality. *There was a guy at the door...* should be acceptable, but *There was this guy at the door...* should increase vividness, noteworthiness, and expected continuation of the referent.

Third, acquisition should show frame-dependence. Children should initially restrict narrative *this* to the learned constructions (story-openings, presentationals) before generalizing. They should

not show across-the-board "indefinite this" independent of constructional context.

If these predictions fail (if *this* behaves exactly like *a* in narrative frames, if it shows no special cataphoric effect, or if children use indefinite *this* freely without constructional anchoring), the constructional account is falsified and a polysemy analysis becomes necessary.

7 Edge cases and objections

7.1 Proper names

Proper names are semantically definite (they refer to unique, identifiable individuals), but they typically lack deital morphology in English. This seems to challenge the correlation between deitality and definiteness, but it also illustrates why the level of analysis matters. English singular names are not determinative lexemes; they're DPs whose semantic profile is definite without ordinary deital marking.

The projectibility-first account predicts this pattern. Names show properties from the definiteness profile (identifiability, uniqueness, anaphoric recoverability) without the typical morphological marking. They're therefore not failed deital determinatives. They're a different realization of semantic definiteness. A bad string such as **two of John* does not show this by itself; it's bad because a singular name denotes an individual rather than a plural domain. More revealing are cases where the level changes: lexicalized article names such as *The Boring Company*, coordinate pluralities such as *two of Brett, Craig, and Michael*, and family-name plurals such as *the Smiths* each involve different DP structures. They should not be collapsed into one diagnostic verdict for bare names.

Languages differ in whether they require overt deital marking on inherently definite referents. English omits articles on singular names, providing a non-deital marker only on exceptional indefinite uses: *a Susan arrived* = 'some person named Susan'. Modern Greek commonly uses the definite article with personal names in ordinary argument positions, for example *o Stavros* 'the Stavros', though article use is conditioned by case, construction, and register (Holton et al., 2012). Both languages treat names as semantically definite; they differ in morphosyntactic realization.

English reveals one version of the logic when names enter constructions with indefinite defaults. Bare plurals are indefinite: *dogs*, *books*, *students*. When a family name needs plural form, the constructional signal (bare plural = indefinite) clashes with the semantic requirement (family name = definite). English resolves this by adding deital marking: *the Smiths*, *the Johnsons*. The article is not redundant here; it overrides the constructional default to preserve definiteness. This differs from bare singular *John*; it provides evidence that names interact with deital morphology at the DP/construction level.

Cross-linguistic variation in article use with names confirms that the profiles are maintained by different processes. The deital profile's distributional restrictions and the definiteness profile's interpretive properties overlap substantially but are not identical. They correlate strongly because grammaticalization and acquisition create conventional pairings. Names can be definite without deital marking (English singular names), require deital marking when constructions signal otherwise (English plural names), or commonly appear with deital marking in ordinary argument positions (Modern Greek personal names).

7.2 Interrogatives and relatives

Interrogative and relative determinatives require special treatment. Most deitality diagnostics presuppose declarative structure. Interrogatives have obligatorily fronted phrases; relatives have distinct clause-internal syntax.

In partitive constructions under standard interrogative force, interrogatives cannot serve as *Y*: **How many of which students passed?* is degraded compared to *How many of the students passed?* Echo questions allow it (*Two of WHICH students?*), but the construction is marked, with distinct prosody and pragmatics. When interrogatives appear in *X* position (*which of the students*, *how many of these books*), they enforce definite-like *Y* just as other quantifiers in *X* do, but the contrast reflects the partitive construction's selectional requirements, not the interrogative's own deital status. Interrogatives also license bare *one* (*Which one?*), unlike deital determinatives. The profile is non-deital under neutral conditions.

For relatives, I follow *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* in treating *that* as a subordinator, not a determinative (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002). It marks subordination and does not realize an argument position. *Which*, by contrast, is a determinative when it appears with an overt head (*in which chapter*). In fused-head constructions (*I read which(ever) you recommended*), it patterns like other fused forms, sometimes deital, sometimes not, depending on the broader structure.

7.3 Exclamatives

Exclamative phrases like *What a mess!* or *So many people!* have clause-type-specific syntax. Most diagnostics do not apply cleanly. Where exclamative phrases surface in declarative contexts, they pattern non-deitally: *There was such a mess* is fine; *??Such a book, which I bought, is rare* is degraded.

Exclamative force (expressing extreme degree) is orthogonal to the deitality profile. When exclamative determinatives appear outside their clause type, they behave like other degree-modified quantifiers: acceptable after *there*, poor hosts for identificational constructions.

7.4 Circularity and collapse objections

The most serious objection is circularity: the diagnostics define the category they purport to identify. If deitality is characterized by resistance to existential *there*, partitive *Y*-licensing, etc., and those same properties are used to identify deital determinatives, haven't we just described the same facts twice?

The reply begins by separating three moments in the argument. Diagnostics identify a synchronic profile. Diachrony and acquisition explain why that profile is not accidental. Projection tests ask whether locating an item or construction in the profile licenses further inferences. Identification need not be independent of every diagnostic property; anti-essentialist categories are often identified by clustered symptoms. The requirement is that the profile support inferences beyond mere relabelling.

First, the diagnostics are independently motivated. Existential *there*, partitives, and identificational constructions are well-studied phenomena with their own syntactic and semantic analyses (Barker, 1998; Lambrecht, 1994; Milsark, 1977). I'm not inventing tests to fit a theory; I'm using established diagnostics to reveal a profile.

Second, the strongest sources and stabilizers are independently attested. Grammaticalization pathways from demonstratives to articles are documented cross-linguistically (Diessel, 1999). Acquisitional overgeneralization of *the* is an empirical finding (Maratsos, 1976). The account does not infer every stabilizer from the data it's meant to explain. It derives predictions from independently motivated diachronic and acquisitional processes.

The deeper worry is collapse: perhaps the diagnostics are not a profile at all but one semantic property (presuppositionality, referentiality, specificity, or familiarity) measured four ways. The answer is dissociation under manipulation. Prosody can rescue existential pivots but not partitive *Y* complements. Specificity can improve identificational hosting without changing partitive *Y*-licensing. Weak

definites preserve deital article morphology but lose the weak reading under partitive *Y*-licensing pressure. Quantifiers such as *each* and *every* resist existential pivots while failing other diagnostics. These splits would be surprising if the diagnostics were just one hidden semantic feature. They're expected if deitality is a ranked profile whose components are related but not identical.

A more sophisticated collapse objection replaces one semantic feature with several: existential *there* tracks information-structural newness, partitives track domain establishment, hosting tracks specificity, and the observed clustering is just the ordinary correlation among those semantic and pragmatic properties. This version is harder to dismiss, and one part is right. The diagnostics are semantically leaky. But a purely semantic bundle leaves two facts unexplained. First, the same historical forms recur across the distributional profile: demonstrative-derived determinatives, including English *the*, *this*, *that*, *these*, and *those*, carry a shared formal lineage described above. The /ð/ pattern is not a diagnostic, but the pattern is a residue of form history that a semantic-only account treats as accidental. Second, the profile supports cross-level predictions: semantic manipulation improves hosting, prosody improves *there*, and neither manipulation supplies a weak partitive *Y*. That pattern is better captured by a level-sensitive morphosyntactic profile with semantic interfaces than by a set of independent semantic filters.

8 Conclusion

I've argued for a principled separation between deitality (a structural profile) and definiteness (a semantic one). The separation is motivated empirically by systematic form–meaning mismatches (Francis & Michaelis, 2003): weak definites, generic definites, narrative *this*, and proper names show that morphological marking and referent identifiability do not align perfectly.

The apparatus comes from anti-essentialist natural-kind theory, but the claim is grammatical. Deitality is justified by projectibility: the category lets us predict which diagnostics travel together, which restrictions survive semantic mismatch, and which parts of the system are sensitive to prosody, construction, dialect, and acquisition. The deital profile includes ranked distributional restrictions (partitive *Y*-licensing, existential *there* resistance, identificational hosting, and the narrower bare *one*-substitution residue) plus a strong tendency to mark semantically definite referents. The definiteness profile includes interpretive properties (identifiability, uniqueness, anaphoric recoverability) plus a strong tendency to be marked by deital morphology.

The analysis separates stable profile, maintenance, and strict homeostasis. Deitality has a projection target and a stable grammatical profile. It also has a plausible source-and-stabilizer account: grammaticalization creates much of the profile historically through property dragging; acquisition helps reproduce it in each generation; interactive alignment, prestige selection, and iterated transmission may stabilize particular regions of the profile. Definiteness is maintained by discourse-pragmatic pressures: common ground management, bridging, and topic continuity create correlations among identifiability, uniqueness, and anaphoric tracking. Nothing in the argument requires deitality to be a single corrective-control system.

The profiles overlap substantially (most semantically definite referents are marked deitally, and most deital marking appears on definite referents) because grammaticalization conventionalized this pairing and discourse efficiency maintains it. The stabilizing pressures are partly distinct, which allows systematic dissociations: weak definites show deital morphology without ordinary token-level definiteness semantics; proper names show definiteness semantics without ordinary deital marking.

Those mismatches show what the category lets us infer about residual morphosyntax once semantics shifts.

The framework generates falsifiable predictions. Prosodic manipulation should affect existential pivots but not partitive *Y*-licensing. Specificity forcing should improve indefinites in identificational environments without reaching deital baselines. Dialectal variation in institutional frames should preserve or lose institutional readings systematically rather than by free determinative substitution. Acquisition should show developmental asymmetries reflecting the source-and-stabilizer account. These predictions distinguish the projectibility-first account from semantic or purely distributional alternatives and are testable through corpus studies, experimental psycholinguistics, and acquisition research.

The approach clarifies the methodological stance required for studying grammatical categories. Identifying grammatical categories of this kind requires empirical investigation (corpus studies, acquisition research, cross-linguistic comparison), not a priori stipulation. The profiles and their stabilizing pressures are discovered through scientific practice because they support generalizations that work. This aligns linguistic ontology with empirical linguistics rather than treating grammatical categories as objects of pure philosophical analysis.

There are two broader implications. First, the approach offers a model for other recalcitrant grammatical categories. Aspect, mood, transitivity, and even major lexical categories like verb and adjective might be fruitfully reanalysed as projectible profiles. The move away from essentialism toward causally grounded profiles could reshape how we think about grammatical ontology.

Second, the framework bridges theoretical divides. By grounding formal categories in diachrony and acquisition, it connects synchronic structure to historical change and cognitive development. The result is a richer picture of how grammatical categories work.

The definiteness problem becomes clearer once we stop asking one profile to do the work of two: one primarily morphosyntactic, one primarily semantic, each comprising properties from both domains but maintained by different causal processes. Their correlation is real and grounded, and the categories remain distinct. Once the categories are separated, they support explanation: they let us predict which diagnostics will travel together, which mismatches will preserve deital residue, and which dimensions of the system will vary across dialects, constructions, and learning stages.

A Provisional Inventory of English Determinatives

The table below is a compact test set rather than a defended taxonomy of every English determinative. The core contrasts are used in the argument above; rows involving fused relatives, exclamatives, and personal determinatives are included to mark empirical terrain for later judgment and corpus work.

Determinative	*there*-resist.	Domain-*Y*	Hosting	*one*-block	Class
Core deital items					
the	✓	✓	✓	✓	DEITAL
this	✓	✓	✓	✓	DEITAL
that	✓	✓	✓	✓	DEITAL
these	✓	✓	✓	✓	DEITAL
those	✓	✓	✓	✓	DEITAL
Universal/distributive quantifiers (mixed)					
each	✓	–	–	✓	Mixed
every	✓	–	–	✓	Mixed
everybody/everyone	✓	–	✓	✓	Mixed
everything	✓	–	✓	✓	Mixed
everywhere	✓	–	✓	✓	Mixed
all	–[a]	–	–	✓	Mixed
both	–[a]	–	–	✓	Mixed
Alternative/negative quantifiers (mixed)					
either	✓	–	–	–	Mixed
neither	✓	–	–	–	Mixed
no	–	–	–	✓	Mixed
nobody/no one	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
nothing	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
nowhere	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
none	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
Indefinites and weak quantifiers					
a/an	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
a certain	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
a few	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
a little	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
another	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
some	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
somebody/someone	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
something	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
somewhere	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
any	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
anybody/anyone	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
anything	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
anywhere	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL

Determinative	*there*-resist.	Domain-*Y*	Hosting	*one*-block	Class
Degree/quantity expressions					
many	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
much	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
few	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
fewer	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
little	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
less	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
more	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
most (proportional)	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
several	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
certain (plural)	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
various	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
multiple	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
enough	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
sufficient	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
umpteen	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
Superlatives and ordinals (deital in referential frames)					
(*the*) *most / fewest / least*[b]	✓	–	✓	✓	DEITAL
last	✓	–	✓	✓	DEITAL
next	✓	–	✓	✓	DEITAL
said	✓	✓	✓	✓	DEITAL
Numerals[c]					
zero	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
one (numeral)	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
two, three, four...	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
ten, twenty...ninety	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
hundred, thousand, million	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
once, twice, thrice	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
Interrogatives (clause-type dependent)[d]					
what	n/a	–	n/a	–	NON-DEITAL
which	n/a	–	n/a	–	NON-DEITAL
whose	n/a	–	n/a	–	NON-DEITAL
how many/much	n/a	–	n/a	–	NON-DEITAL
what/which kind of	n/a	–	n/a	–	NON-DEITAL
Relatives and fused relatives[e]					
which (with overt head)	n/a	–	n/a	–	NON-DEITAL
what (fused relative)	✓	✓	✓	✓	Provisional
whatever (ignorance)	✓	✓	✓	✓	Provisional
whatever (free-choice)	✓	–	–	–	Mixed
whichever (ignorance)	✓	✓	✓	✓	Provisional
whichever (free-choice)	✓	–	–	–	Mixed

Determinative	*there*-resist.	Domain-*Y*	Hosting	*one*-block	Class
Exclamatives (clause-type dependent)[f]					
what (exclamative)	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
what a	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
such	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
such a	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
so many/much	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
how many/much (excl.)	–	–	–	–	NON-DEITAL
Personal determinatives[g]					
us	n/a	✓	n/a	n/a	Provisional
we	n/a	–	n/a	n/a	Provisional
you	n/a	✓	n/a	n/a	Provisional

Table 1: Provisional inventory of English determinatives. ✓ = shows the DEITAL pattern named by the column; – = fails the pattern; n/a = diagnostic undefined for the construction type. *There*-resist. means *resists* post-*there* pivothood under neutral prosody (i.e., exhibits the definiteness effect), not that the item occurs after *there* (McNally, 2011; Milsark, 1977). Domain-*Y* means that the item can supply the domain-establishing *Y* complement in a true partitive. *One*-block means that the item blocks bare anaphoric *one* under the narrow DP-package diagnostic, not that it licenses *one*. For class, DEITAL = shows convergence across the ranked diagnostics (prototypical profile members); NON-DEITAL = fails the ranked diagnostics; Mixed = shows partial profile membership; Provisional = included as a target for later validation rather than used as evidence in the paper. [a]Coordination rescues *there*-pivot. [b]Determinative superlative use only (not proportional quantifier). [c]See (Reynolds, 2025) for why only these. [d]Interrogatives fronted in questions; diagnostics largely undefined. [e]Fused relatives pattern varies by reading (ignorance-definite vs. free-choice). [f]Exclamatives in declarative contexts pattern non-deitally; frame-initial uses undefined. [g]Personal determinatives are limited to constructions such as *us linguists* and require separate treatment; the partitive contrast *two of us/you* vs. **two of we* is confounded by case selection by *of*.

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